

Revenue Models

2026

Digital products, platforms & AI-first startups

“Monetization is not just pricing — it’s a strategic design decision.”

The best question is not

“how can I charge?”

— it’s

“what value am I delivering, and who benefits the most from it?”

Core Revenue Models (1/2)

Most successful products combine several models, evolving as they mature.



1

Subscription

Recurring fee for access. Predictable, scalable, but retention is critical.



Netflix · Notion · ChatGPT Plus

REVERSE TRIAL full access first, then downgrade — the most effective at converting



2

Transactional

Pay per purchase or feature. Simple, fast monetization; unpredictable revenue.



App Store · Gumroad



3

Usage-Based

Pay for what you consume. Aligns with value — ideal for AI products.



AWS · Stripe · OpenAI API



4

Freemium

Free core product, paid upgrades. Low-friction acquisition; conversion risk.



Canva · Trello

Core Revenue Models (2/2)

AI-native monetization builds on these classics —
it doesn't replace them.



5 Marketplace

% commission on each transaction. Scales with volume; needs liquidity on both sides.



Airbnb · Uber ·
Upwork



6 Advertising

Revenue from selling audience exposure. Drives adoption; can damage UX at scale.



Google · YouTube



7 Licensing

Pay to use technology, data, or IP. High margins, strong B2B fit.



Unity · Google
Maps API



8 Data & Insights

Monetize aggregated insights and analytics. High enterprise value; privacy risk.



Palantir ·
SimilarWeb

ALSO SEEN: seat-based pricing, add-ons, reverse trial, in-app purchases, affiliate/recommendation, community-supported (donations) — niche or complementary, rarely the core model for an AI-first MVP.

Monetization in the Post-AI World

THE CENTER OF GRAVITY IS MOVING:

seat-based license → usage-based → **outcome-based pricing**



1



Pattern 1 · Usage-Based / Token Pricing

Charge per unit of AI work actually consumed

“Price what the model actually costs to run.”

CLAUDE API

\$2 / \$10

per million input / output tokens

EXAMPLE

Claude API: \$2 / \$10 per million input / output tokens on Sonnet 5. The price scales with actual use.

WHY IT MATTERS

Revenue tracks compute cost one-to-one. The margin is a deliberate, visible markup — not a guess.

FOR YOUR MVP

If you wrap an LLM, know your cost-per-call before you price. This only works if you’ve measured it.

UNIT CHARGED: \$ per million tokens (input / output) · billed exactly as much as the model runs



Pattern 2 · Hybrid: Subscription + Usage Pass-Through



A flat subscription is the door; usage is billed near cost

“The subscription gets them in. Usage keeps the price honest.”

CURSOR

\$60B

acquisition in under four years

EXAMPLE

Tiered subscriptions from \$20 to \$200/month with a dollar credit pool for premium models. Overages bill at the raw API rate — no markup — except Max Mode, at API rate + 20%.

WHY IT MATTERS

Cursor moved from a fixed “500 requests” plan to near-pure cost pass-through: margin sits in the subscription and in premium modes. An MIT side-project reached a \$60B acquisition in under four years.

FOR YOUR MVP

A subscription alone caps your upside. Usage on top captures the heaviest users without scaring off casual ones.

UNIT CHARGED: flat subscription tier + raw API rate on overages (API rate + 20% only in Max Mode)



Pattern 3 · Outcome-Based Pricing

Pay for the result, not for access or usage

“No result, no charge.”

INTERCOM FIN

\$0.99

per resolved
conversation

SIERRA

\$1.50

per resolved outcome

EXAMPLE

Intercom Fin charges \$0.99 per resolved conversation — no platform fees, no opaque contracts. Sierra charges ~\$1.50 per resolved outcome and, by its own account, nothing when the case goes unresolved or escalates to a human.

WHY IT MATTERS

Revenue is tied to validated value — the closest thing to a pure “value-based price” in pricing theory.

FOR YOUR MVP

The Lean Startup version of pricing: charge for the validated outcome, not for building. Define “success” for your user first.

UNIT CHARGED: \$ per resolved outcome · zero cost if the agent doesn’t deliver the result

The Shift in Practice

From seat-based license to value-aligned pricing,
across verticals

	PRODUCT	VERTICAL	PRICING UNIT	SIGNAL
	Claude API / Claude Code	Dev infrastructure	Per token consumed	The usage-based benchmark for AI-native products
	Cursor	Coding	Subscription + raw API pass-through (Max Mode: +20%)	\$60B acquisition in under 4 years
 	Intercom Fin / Sierra	Customer support	Per resolved outcome	No result, no charge
	Harvey	Legal	Premium per-seat → shifting to revenue-share	\$11B valuation on ~\$190M ARR
	Perplexity	Consumer search	Subscription-first + publisher revenue-share	Dropped ads; revenue +50% after the switch
 	Bland AI vs. HubSpot / AiSDR	Sales outreach	Infra: per minute · App layer: seat + credit per lead	Infrastructure vs. application-layer pricing

Infrastructure layer charges for raw compute (tokens, minutes). **Application layer** charges for business outcomes (leads, resolutions). Know which layer your MVP lives in.

“The tighter your price is tied to value delivered, the stronger your model.”